ERA 5

First Party System & American Identity

1796 – 1800

Federalists vs. Democratic-Republicans · Adams · a new national culture

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did political parties, foreign crises, and a new national culture forge — and divide — an American identity?

KEY TERMS

XYZ Affair · Alien & Sedition Acts · Washington's Farewell · republican culture · cotton gin

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 3.11–3.13 · AMSCO Ch. 3.11–3.13

ADAMS & THE AGE OF CRISIS

The First Party System

The XYZ Affair



- French agents demanded bribes before they would negotiate with U.S. diplomats.
- Outraged Americans rallied: 'Millions for defense, not one cent for tribute!'
- An undeclared naval '**quasi-war**' with France followed.

The Alien & Sedition Acts, 1798

Opponents called them a betrayal of the First Amendment

I

Naturalization Act

Made immigrants wait 14 years to become citizens.

II

Alien Act

Let the president deport 'dangerous' foreigners.

III

Sedition Act

Made it a crime to criticize the government—a blow to free speech.

Washington's Farewell Address

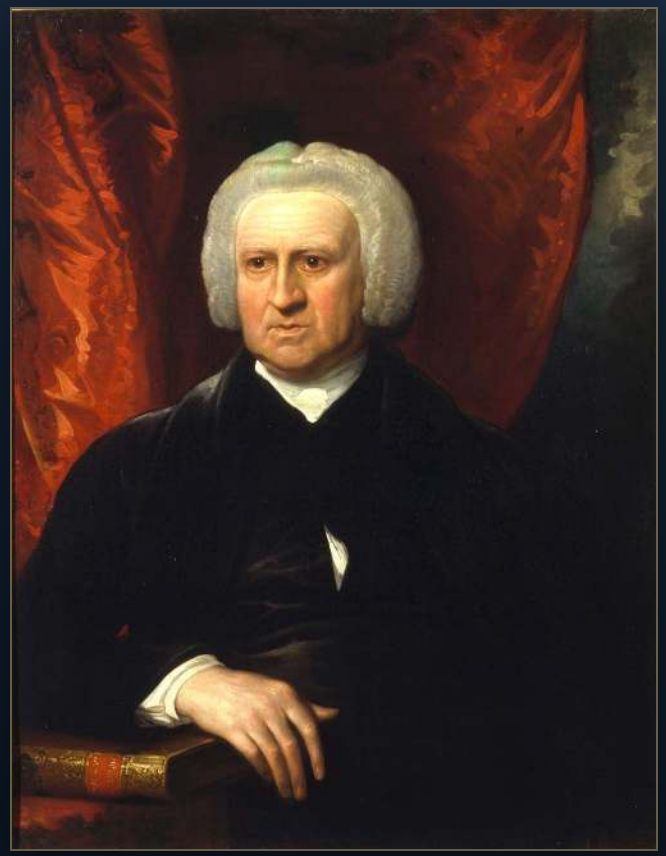


- Washington declined a third term—setting a two-term precedent.
- He warned against the dangers of **political factions**.
- He urged the nation to **avoid permanent foreign alliances**.

SECTION

A New American Identity

An American Culture Emerges



- Painters like **Benjamin West** and **Gilbert Stuart** celebrated American subjects.
- **Phillis Wheatley** became the first published African American poet.
- A distinctly American cultural voice began to take shape.

Defining an American Language

- **Noah Webster** created a distinctly American English.
- His spellers and dictionary standardized American spelling.
- Language became a tool of national identity.



Republican Architecture



- **Jefferson** modeled **Monticello** and the University of Virginia on classical forms.
- Washington, D.C. was designed to embody **republican** ideals.
- Architecture expressed the values of the new republic.

SECTION

Movement in the Early Republic

The Cotton Gin



- **Eli Whitney**'s 1793 **cotton gin** made cotton wildly profitable.
- It transformed the economy of the Deep South.
- Tragically, it made slavery more valuable—not less.

The Cotton Gin's Dark Legacy

INVENTION

Cotton Gin

Whitney's machine cleans cotton 50x faster.

→

BOOM

Cotton Is King

Cotton becomes hugely profitable across the South.

→

EXPANSION

Slavery Spreads

Demand for enslaved labor surges into new western lands.

A Nation on the Move

I

Westward Migration

Settlers pushed across the Appalachians into new territory.

II

Native Conflict

The **Northwest Indian War** ended in the Treaty of Greenville (1795).

III

Rising Tensions

Expansion fueled conflict over land—and over slavery's spread.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

First Party System & Identity

1. The first party system matured under Adams—inflamed by the **XYZ Affair** and the **Alien & Sedition Acts**.
2. Washington's **Farewell Address** warned against factions and permanent foreign alliances.
3. A distinct **national culture** arose in art, language, and architecture—even as the **cotton gin** deepened slavery and sectional tension.

DISCUSS & APPLY

First Party System & Identity

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

ARGUMENTATION

Were the **Alien & Sedition Acts** protecting national security or betraying the Revolution? Make and defend a claim.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did a shared **national culture** emerge even as regional divisions deepened?

CAUSATION

Explain how disagreements between **Hamilton and Jefferson** caused the first party system.

Up next — **Lesson 11: The Era of Jefferson** (Louisiana Purchase & the Marshall Court)